

CHAPTER ONE

The man from England

In the town of Kasama in Zambia, there's a big game of football today. A lot of people are watching. Kasama United are playing against Black Star. It's one goal to Kasama and one goal to Black Star. Now there are only five minutes until the end of the game.

The Kasama goalkeeper has the ball. He looks up the field.

'To me!' shouts Mumba Siwale. 'Kick it to me!' Mumba is only seventeen years old but he's Kasama's best player.

The Kasama goalkeeper kicks the ball up the field. Mumba takes the ball on his foot, and then he turns and runs towards the Black Star goal. He runs past one Black Star player, and then past another player. The goalkeeper comes out, but Mumba takes the ball past him. He shoots. He scores. It's a goal!

The Kasama fans stand up and shout, 'Goal! Goal to Kasama! Goal to Mumba!' They start shouting Mumba's name, again and again. 'Mum-ba! Mum-ba! Mum-ba!'

The game ends. The score is Kasama United 2 - Black Star 1. Kasama win the game.

Mumba is very happy. Sam Chipata is happy too. He's the manager of Kasama United. 'A great game, Mumba,' says Sam. 'Now, I want you to meet a man from England.' A tall man in a black suit is standing beside Sam.

'This is Tom Delaney,' says Sam.

Tom Delaney shakes Mumba's hand and says, 'Hello, Mumba.'

'Hello, Mr Delaney,' says Mumba.

'Tom is from Liverpool,' says Sam. 'He's from Mersey City. He wants to talk to you.'

Mersey City? Mumba thinks. They're my favourite team. Michael Woko plays for Mersey City. Does Mr Delaney want me to play for them too?

'Mumba, I want you to come to England,' says 'Tom Delaney. 'I want you to play for Mersey City.'

Mumba can't believe it. He doesn't speak.

Tom Delaney waits. 'What do you say, Mumba? Do you want to play for Mersey City?'

'Of course I do,' says Mumba. 'But I can't believe it. I love Mersey City! They're my favourite team. They play in League One. I watch them on television. And Michael Woko is my favourite player. But -'

'You have to talk to Mumba's family, Tom,' says Sam Chipata. 'Mumba is only seventeen years old.'

'Of course,' says 'Tom Delaney. 'I have a letter for Mumba's father. He has to sign it.'

'My father is dead,' says Mumba. 'You have to talk to my mother. She's at home.'

Mumba lives with his mother and his young brother, Goodson. Goodson is a good footballer too. At Mumba's house, his mother, Edith Siwale, listens to Tom Delaney.

'Your son is a very good footballer, Mrs Siwale. We want him to come to England and play for Mersey City. They are a very big team. They play in League One. Mumba is going to be a very rich young man.'

Mrs Siwale doesn't speak.

Tom Delaney smiles and says, 'He can buy a big house for you. And a car.'

'We have a car,' says Mrs Siwale. 'I am a teacher. We are not a poor family.'

'But our car is very old, Mother,' says Mumba.

'It's a good car,' his mother says to him. 'We don't need another car.' She looks at Tom Delaney. 'You talk about money,' she says, 'but what is going to happen to my son in England? England is not like Zambia. It's a cold country. And the people are cold too. Is he going to be happy in your country? Mumba is very young -'

'Mother, I'm seventeen. I am a man.'

'Be quiet,' says Mrs Siwale. She turns back to Tom Delaney. 'I don't know you, Mr Delaney,' she says. 'And I don't like this talk about money.'

'But I want to play football in England,' says Mumba. 'I want to play for Mersey City.'

'Be quiet,' his mother says again. 'I am thinking.' She turns to Tom Delaney. 'Come back tomorrow, Mr Delaney,' she says. 'Come and eat with us. You are new to Zambia. You have to know something about us. Come tomorrow.'

CHAPTER TWO

Goodbye to Kasama

Tom Delaney comes to the Siwale house again. He eats with the family. Sam Chipata is there too.

'Thank you for the food, Mrs Siwale,' says Tom Delaney. 'It's very good. I'm happy to be in your home with your family. Families are important. Our club, Mersey City, is a family. We look after our players.'

Mrs Siwale listens, but she doesn't speak.

'They have players from many countries, Mother,' says Mumba.

'Mumba is right, Mrs Siwale,' says Sam. 'Mersey City have players from all over the world. They have other players from Africa.'

'They have Michael Woko,' says Mumba. 'He's from Nigeria. And he's a great player.'

'That's right,' says Mr Delaney. 'Michael Woko is very happy in England. Mumba can be happy there too.'

'Mersey City is a good club, Mrs Siwale,' says Sam. 'I know the people there. They look after their players. You can sign Mr Delaney's letter.'

'What do you say, Mother?' asks Mumba. 'Can I go to England? Can I play for Mersey City?'

Mumba's mother sits and thinks. Then she says, 'Mumba, you are seventeen years old. You are young - you are only a boy. But you are also a man. Your father is dead, and you are the man in this house. You want to be a good footballer. You want to play in a good team. You are right.'

You have to go to England and play for this English club. It's the right team for you.'

Then she turns to Tom Delaney. 'Give me your letter, Mr Delaney,' she says.

He gives it to her and she signs it. 'Then she says, 'Go, Mumba. Go to England. And be happy!' She kisses her son.

Four weeks later, Mumba and his family are at Lusaka Airport. They are waiting for the plane to London. Sam Chipata is there too, with Mumba's friends from Kasama United.

'I don't understand,' says Goodson Siwale. 'The plane is going to London but you are going to Liverpool.'

Mumba laughs. 'First I have to go to London,' he says. 'Then Mr Delaney is going to meet me at London Airport and take me to Liverpool.'

'Are you going to meet Michael Woko?' Goodson asks.

'I'm going to play with Michael Woko!' says Mumba. 'We're going to be in the same team!'

'Listen,' says Sam. 'They're talking about your flight.' They listen: All passengers on Flight ZM456 to London please go to Gate 2. Gate 2 for passengers on the London flight.

'That's your flight, Mumba,' says Sam. 'You have to go now.'

Mumba shakes Sam's hand. Then he hugs his brother. His mother says, 'Goodbye, Mumba. Call us from England. And email us. Promise me.'

Mumba kisses her and says, 'I promise, Mother. Goodbye.'

The flight to London is long. Mumba sleeps. After seven hours, the plane lands in London. Mumba looks out of the window. The sky is grey and there is no sun. It is very different from Kasama, but Mumba is very excited.

Tom Delaney is waiting for him at the airport. He smiles and shakes Mumba's hand. 'How are you, Mumba?'

'I'm very well, Mr Delaney,' says Mumba. 'I'm happy to be here. I'm very excited about playing for Mersey City.'

'I have something to tell you, Mumba,' says Tom Delaney. He isn't smiling now.

'What is it?' asks Mumba.

'I'm sorry, Mumba,' says Tom Delaney, 'but you're not going to play for Mersey City.'

'What? I'm not?' asks Mumba. 'What are you saying?'

'Come on,' says Tom Delaney. 'We can't talk here. I can tell you about it in the car.'

CHAPTER THREE

News from England

Tom Delaney and Mumba drive away from the airport.

'I don't understand,' says Mumba. 'Where are we going? Are we going to Liverpool?'

'No, we're not,' says Tom Delaney. 'You're not going to play for Mersey City - not now. I'm sorry, Mumba, but Mersey City don't want you now.'

'But in Kasama, you -'

'Forget about Kasama,' says Tom Delaney. 'You're in England now.'

'What about the letter?'

'Forget about the letter,' says Tom Delaney. 'Listen, Mumba, you're not ready for Mersey City. You're young. You need to play more football. And you can! Another team wants you.'

'Another team? What team?'

'You're going to play for Blackport United. They want good young players -'

'Blackport United? I don't know this team,' says Mumba. 'Do they play in League One?'

'No, Mumba. They play in League Three. But they are a good club for you. They have a good manager. And they look after young players. I'm taking you to Blackport.'

Mumba doesn't speak. He wants to cry, but he doesn't. He looks out of the window. The streets are grey.

I'm not going to play for Mersey City, he thinks. I'm not going to play with Michael Woko. I'm going to play for Blackport United - but that's not the right team for me!

From: mumbas@blackport.org.uk

To: ediths@zamcom.zm

Hello Mother

How are you? Are you all well in Kasama?

It's awful here! Blackport is an awful town. It's cold and dirty and it rains here all the time. It's raining now. I'm in bed. I'm not well, and I'm not playing for the team this week.

I have no friends here. The other players don't talk to me. And football in England is very different from football in Zambia. The players in other teams kick you. And Blackport United is not the right team for me.

Is the sun shining in Kasama now? I want to come home.

With love to everyone at home

Your son

Mumba

From: ediths@zamcom.zm

To: mumbas@blackport.org.uk

My dear son

I am sorry to read your email. Life is different in England. You are not happy now. I know that. But you have to do your best. You have to work hard. England is different from Zambia. But there are good people there. You have to make friends with the other players. You have to understand them. Then they can be your friends.

Your loving mother

(The sun is not shining in Kasama today. It is raining here. And it's going to rain for the next four weeks!)

Mumba reads his mother's email. She is right, he thinks. I have to make friends. I have to understand the English players. And I have to start today!

CHAPTER FOUR

The right team

Lee Miller is looking at his mobile phone. 'Hey, look at this, Mumba,' he says.

'What is it, Lee?' asks Mumba.

Lee and Mumba are friends. Lee is quiet, like Mumba. He doesn't shout. He plays for Blackport too, but he's not like the other Blackport players.

'We're going to play a big club - a League One club.'

'Which club?' Mumba asks.

'Mersey City,' says Lee. 'We're going to play against Mersey City. What do you think about that?'

Things at Blackport are okay for Mumba now. It's April and it doesn't rain every day. Sometimes the sun shines! And Mumba is playing in the Blackport United first team. He is scoring goals and the Blackport fans like him.

'Mum-ba!' they shout. 'Mum-ba!'

Blackport United's manager is Ron Carter. He likes Mumba too. Some of the big clubs come to watch his young Zambian player. Some of them want Mumba to come to their club. But Blackport don't want Mumba to go. 'Mumba Siwale is staying at Blackport,' says Ron.

Mumba is happy to stay at Blackport now. And now Blackport are going to play against Mersey City! I want to play with Michael Woko, thinks Mumba. But now I'm going to play against him!

'We can beat Mersey City,' Mumba says to Lee.

'But they're a big club, and we're a small club,' says Lee.

'We can beat them,' Mumba says again.

Back in Kasama, Goodson Siwale sits at the computer. He's listening to the game on the radio:

It's half time and the score is Blackport United 1 - Mersey City 1. Yes, Blackport from League Three and Mersey City, the League One club, have one goal each! And that's thanks to a great goal by Blackport's young African player, Mumba Siwale.

And now the second half of the game is starting. Lee Miller of Blackport has the ball. He looks up and sees Siwale. He kicks the ball to Siwale. Siwale turns and shoots. He scores! It's another goal from Mumba Siwale! I don't believe it! Now it's 2 - 1 to Blackport, thanks to Mumba Siwale. Two goals! He's a great young player!

Now everyone here is asking the same question: Are Blackport United of League Three going to beat Mersey City, the big team of League One?

'Mother!' Goodson says. 'Come and listen. Mumba's team are going to win!'

But Blackport United don't beat Mersey City. Michael Woko scores two goals and Mersey City win the game by three goals to two.

At the end of the game, Michael Woko comes up to Mumba and shakes his hand. 'A great game, Siwale,' he says. 'Two great goals!'

'Two great goals to you too,' says Mumba. 'Can I please have your shirt? You can have my shirt.'

'Yes, okay.'

Michael gives Mumba his shirt. Mumba gives his shirt to Michael, and the two players shake hands again.

The Blackport fans are shouting Mumba's name. 'Mum- ha, Mum-ba!'

And then Ron Carter comes up to him. 'A great game, Mumba,' he says. And now I want you to meet someone. You know him.'

A tall man in a black suit is behind Ron. It's Tom Delaney.

'Hello, Mumba,' he says.

'Hello, Mr Delaney,' Mumba says. But he isn't happy to see him. What does he want? he thinks.

Tom Delaney smiles and says, 'You're wearing a Mersey City shirt, Mumba. That's good to see!'

'Oh, it's Michael Woko's shirt,' says Mumba.

'I've got good news for you,' Tom Delaney says. 'We want you to come and play for Mersey City. What do you say?'

Can I believe him? Mumba thinks. But he doesn't speak.

'Give Mr Delaney an answer, Mumba,' says Ron. 'What do you say?'

'It's okay, Ron,' says Tom Delaney. 'Listen, Mumba, I understand. You're thinking, Can I believe him? I'm sorry about last year. But it's true. Mersey City want you to play for them. You're ready for League One now.'

Mumba turns to Ron and asks, 'What do you say, Ron?'

'It's okay, Mumba,' says Ron. 'I understand. You have to go. Mersey City is the right team for you now.'

The right team? Yes, Mumba thinks. I'm going to play for the right team now.

'So, what do you say, Mumba?' asks Tom Delaney.

'Yes!'

CHAPTER FIVE

The big game

One year later

From: mumbas@merseycity.org.uk

To: ediths@zamcom.zm

Hello Mother

How are you? I am very happy in Liverpool. I am playing well. I play in the Mersey City second team, but sometimes I get a game in the first team. And then I play with Michael Woko!

Michael and I are great friends. He's very nice to me and helps me. He wants to come to Kasama!

The team is playing well this year. Tomorrow we are playing against a Spanish team, Sporting Catalunya, in the final of the Euro Cup. But I'm not going to play in the game. I'm a substitute - I have to sit and watch it. But sometimes substitutes go on and play. Who knows?

The game is on television. Are you going to watch it? With love to everyone at home

Your son

Mumba

From: ediths@zamcom.zm

To: mumbas@merseycity.org.uk

My dear son

I know about the big game tomorrow. All the newspapers here are talking about it. They are all talking about you too.

There are big television screens in the centre of Kasama. Thousands of people are going to watch it there.

And yes, I'm going to watch it too! Good luck, Mumba.

Your loving mother

It's the day of the big game - Mersey City against Sporting Catalunya in the Euro Cup final in Frankfurt. There are thousands of fans at the game. They are shouting for the two teams - some for the English team, and some for the Spanish team. Mumba sits with the other substitutes and watches the game.

It's a great game, but there are no goals. The Spanish goalkeeper is playing well. Three times Michael Woko shoots and three times the Spanish goalkeeper stops the ball.

In their home, Goodson and Edith Siwale are watching the game on television:

Mersey City can't score. The Spanish goalkeeper stops every shot. There are only ten minutes to go... Now what's this? There's something wrong with Michael Woko. He's coming off! This is very bad for Mersey City. Who's going to come on for the last ten minutes? It's... Yes, it's the young player from Zambia, Mumba Siwale! He's a good player, but he's only eighteen years old. You have to ask: What can he do?

'Do you see, Mother?' says Goodson. 'Mumba's going on!'

Edith is crying. But she's smiling too. 'Yes, I see. Play well, Mumba.'

Mumba is very excited. He's playing in the Euro Cup final! The game is very fast. He can't get the ball. Then Mersey City get a corner kick. There is only one minute left now. Mumba waits. The ball comes over and he jumps and heads the ball towards the goal. The Spanish goalkeeper tries to stop it, but he can't. It's a goal! A goal for Mersey City! The other players run up to Mumba and hug him.

'It's our Cup!' they shout. 'It's our Cup!'

The game ends, and Mersey City win 1 - 0.

The Mersey City fans cheer and shout. 'Mum-ba! Mum- ba! Mum-ba!'

Now a television reporter is talking to Mumba and Michael Woko. 'A great game, Michael,' he says. 'How does it feel to win the Cup?'

'It feels great. But talk to Mumba here. What a great goal!'

'Okay, Mumba. How does it feel to win the Cup?'

'I'm very happy. I don't score many goals with my head. But it's not about me, it's about the team. Mersey City is a great team. And Michael here is a real friend. He helps me so much.'

'Thousands of people in Zambia are watching the game. What do you want to say to them?'

'I want to say thanks to all the people in Zambia. I'm going to come back to Kasama soon.'

'Mumba, someone in Kasama wants to talk to you. Look at this screen.'

Mumba looks at the television screen and sees his mother.

'Hello, Mumba,' she says. 'I'm very happy for you, son. Are you going to come home soon?'

'Yes, I am,' says Mumba. 'Can I bring Michael Woko with me, Mother?'

His mother laughs. 'Oh yes,' she says. 'Michael can come too!'

- THE END -

Hope you have enjoyed the reading!

